

M1.2 You Can't Handle the Truth

Boyce, Jacob
Social Studies_7-9

You Can't Handle the Truth

In this lesson we cover how humans are bad at seeing the truth for what it is, our natural tendency is to take mental shortcuts. Where that often serves us well we should be mindful of when and how we are doing it.

Overarching Question:
What are the limitations we have when deciding whether to believe in conspiracies?

Objectives:
~ show understanding of the standard based on discussion
~ discuss beliefs
~ express criticality of beliefs
~ accept others being critical of beliefs

M1.2: You can’t handle the truth

Module1.1 Class 2
Agenda 1120-1220, 1255-1355+:
1120-1140: Decision Making Part 2
1140-1200: The Psychological Struggle of Having Belief Questioned
1200-1220: Conspiracy research
Lunch
1255-1320: Discussion with beliefs questioned
1320-1330: You can't handle the truth explanation
1330-1355: When Prophecy fails Storytime
+ Conspiracy Theory Game

Module 1.2 Class 2
1145-1200 When Prophecy Fails Storytime
1200-1220: Tricks of the Trade Assignment & Heuristics examples
Lunch
1255-1315: M2.1 ACH Decision Making
1315-1340 Heuristic Assignment
1340-1355 Conspiracy Theory Game

Module 1.2 Class 3
1145-1220 Heuristics presentations
Lunch
1255-1355 M2.1 Final Decision Recording

Standards:
CC.8.6.9-10.A
Develop claim(s) and counterclaims fairly and

thoroughly, supplying the most relevant data and evidence for each while pointing out the strengths and limitations of both claim(s) and counterclaims in a discipline appropriate form that anticipates the audience's knowledge level, concerns, values, and possible biases.

Lecture Outline: The Psychological Struggle of Having Beliefs Questioned

Purpose: Understanding why it is psychologically challenging to have our beliefs questioned and why we find it difficult to accept others' beliefs as valid. This next portion of the class, I am going to ask others to 'attack' your position on a conspiracy theory you actually believe in. Only *ad hominem* attacks (insulting you or your intelligence will not be allowed).

Cognitive Dissonance

Self-Concept and Identity
Top Down Psychology
Confirmation Bias
Emotional Attachment

Worldview Defense
Ingroup-Outgroup Dynamics
Resistance to Change

Empathy Gap
Threat to Self-Concept

Open-Mindedness
Self-Reflection
Dialogue and Exposure

Hopeful takeaway: By recognizing these psychological processes, we can better manage the discomfort of having our beliefs questioned and keep an open mind towards others beliefs.

Discussion Rules:

Everyone speaks.... Everyone listens...

Take 15 minutes to come up with 3 separate conspiracies and reasons for each (see below):

Aloud:

What is a conspiracy theory you think is true and why?

Person to the right of presenter, express a reason to be skeptical of the conspiracy.

What is a conspiracy you find bogus and why?

Person to the left of the presenter, express a reason to support the conspiracy.
What is a conspiracy theory you find fascinating and/or just like and why?

In private:
Whose responses seemed the most credible and why?
What do you think the difference between believeing and knowing is?

Assignment: Demonstrating Heuristics in Action

Objective:

After learning about heuristics and biases, your task is to create a practical example that demonstrates how a specific heuristic influences decision-making. You will be assigned a heuristic and must develop a scenario that reliably showcases this heuristic in action. Your example should work most of the time for most people.

Grading Criteria:

- **Accuracy of Setup and Expected Result (3 points)**:
  - 3 points: The setup reliably demonstrates the heuristic, and the expected result accurately reflects the heuristic in action.
  - 2 points: The setup mostly demonstrates the heuristic, but there may be minor issues with

Task:

Create a PowerPoint presentation consisting of three slides:
Setup Slide: Describe the scenario you've designed to demonstrate the heuristic.
Expected Result Slide: Predict the outcome or behavior you expect from the participants based on the heuristic.
Explanation Slide: Clearly and concisely explain how the heuristic or bias influenced the outcome.

Slide Details:

Setup Slide:
Clearly describe the situation, task, or question you will present to participants.
Include any necessary materials or prompts.
Make sure the setup is straightforward and can be easily understood by your peers.

Expected Result Slide:
Predict what most participants will likely think, choose, or do in response to the setup.
Explain why you expect this result, based on the heuristic you are demonstrating.

Explanation Slide:
Provide a clear, concise explanation of how the

- the expected result.
  - 1 point: The setup partially demonstrates the heuristic, but the expected result may be unclear or not well-aligned with the heuristic.
  - 0 points: The setup does not effectively demonstrate the heuristic, and the expected result is inaccurate or missing.

- **Clarity and Precision of Explanation (3 points)**:
  - 3 points: The explanation is clear, precise, and concise, effectively connecting the heuristic to the outcome.
  - 2 points: The explanation is mostly clear but may lack some precision or detail in connecting the heuristic to the outcome.
  - 1 point: The explanation is somewhat unclear or lacks focus, making it difficult to see how the heuristic influenced the outcome.
  - 0 points: The explanation is unclear, inaccurate, or missing, and does not effectively connect the heuristic to the outcome.

heuristic led to the predicted outcome.
Connect your explanation directly to the concept of the heuristic, showing how it influenced decision-making in your scenario.
Keep your explanation focused and easy to follow.

Tricks of the Trade: Heuristics

After being assigned a heuristic, develop a way that you could reliably (not every time for everyone but most of the time for most people) display your heuristic in action.

- **Availability Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Making decisions based on the information that is most readily available or most easily comes to mind.
  - **Example**: After seeing news reports about airplane accidents, a person might overestimate the risk of flying.
  - Game:
- **Representativeness Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Judging the probability of an event based on how closely it matches a prototype or stereotype.
  - **Example**: Assuming someone is a librarian rather than a salesperson because they are quiet, methodical, and enjoy reading.
- **Affect Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Making decisions based on emotions rather than objective data.
  - **Example**: Deciding not to invest in a stock because of a gut feeling, despite solid financial indicators suggesting it's a good choice.

- **Satisficing**:
  - **Description**: Settling for a solution that is "good enough" rather than the optimal one, especially when under time pressure.
  - **Example**: Choosing the first restaurant that looks decent when hungry instead of searching for the best one in town.
- **Recognition Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Preferring the option that is more familiar or recognizable.
  - **Example**: Choosing a well-known brand over an unfamiliar one, assuming that the familiar brand is of better quality.
- **Confirmation Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Focusing on information that confirms one's preconceptions and ignoring information that contradicts them.
  - **Example**: A person who believes in astrology might remember instances when their horoscope was accurate and forget times when it was not.
- **Anchoring Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Relying too heavily on the first piece of information encountered (the "anchor") when making decisions.
  - **Example**: If a person sees a shirt priced at $100 and then sees another at $50, they might perceive the second shirt as cheap, even if $50 is more than they would normally spend.
- **Simulation Heuristic**:
  - **Description**: Predicting the likelihood of an event based on how easily one can imagine it happening.
  - **Example**: Assuming that a near-miss accident was more likely to have resulted in a crash simply because it is easy to imagine that outcome.
- **Tversky and Kahneman's Loss Aversion**:
  - **Description**: The tendency to prefer avoiding losses rather than acquiring equivalent gains.
  - **Example**: Refusing to sell a stock that has lost value because the pain of losing money is greater than the potential pleasure of reinvesting in a potentially profitable stock.
- **Default Heuristic**:

- **Description**: Opting for the default or pre-set option when faced with a decision, especially when it is easier or less effortful.
- **Example**: Sticking with the default settings on a phone or computer rather than customizing them, because it is easier.

Resources and extra research

List of Cognitive Biases and Heuristics (use this one for your research)

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Heuristic_(psychology)

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_cognitive_biases

https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC10106569/

Exit Ticket: On a flashcard answer the following (knowing full well that it will be read for the following weeks warm up):

Why is it important to be critical of belief?

Additional discussion:

How have you seen these bias played out in the current presidential election, please provide specific examples that are grounded in truth as not to play into the bias.

Here are some historic examples:

1. **Confirmation Bias**
   - **Impact on Elections**: Voters tend to seek out and believe information that confirms their pre-existing beliefs and ignore information that contradicts those beliefs. This bias has contributed to the polarization of news sources, with individuals gravitating toward outlets that align with their political views.
   - **Examples**:
     - **Republican**: During the 2016 election, many supporters of Donald Trump focused on news sources and social media that reinforced their beliefs about his business acumen and outsider status, while dismissing reports that questioned his qualifications or business practices.
     - **Democrat**: In the 2020 election, some supporters of Joe Biden focused on media that highlighted his experience and empathy, while dismissing concerns about his age or alleged cognitive decline.
2. **Availability Heuristic**
   - **Impact on Elections**: This bias causes voters to make decisions based on the information that is most readily available or memorable, which is often influenced by recent events or media coverage.
   - **Examples**:
     - **Republican**: In the 2016 election, the focus on terrorism and immigration issues, amplified by high-profile attacks and Trump's strong stance on building a border wall, made these topics more salient for voters.
     - **Democrat**: In the 2020 election, the widespread coverage of the COVID-19 pandemic and the handling of the crisis by the Trump administration made health care and pandemic response key issues for many voters, benefiting Joe Biden’s campaign.
3. **Anchoring Bias**

- **Impact on Elections**: Voters' opinions can be influenced by the first piece of information they receive about a candidate or issue, which then serves as a reference point for all subsequent judgments.
- **Examples**:
  - **Republican**: In the 2016 election, Donald Trump's early and persistent labeling of Hillary Clinton as "Crooked Hillary" anchored voters' perceptions of her, making it difficult for her to shake off the image, regardless of the information that followed.
  - **Democrat**: In the 2020 election, the early framing of Trump's handling of the COVID-19 pandemic as chaotic and ineffective by the Biden campaign anchored many voters' views, influencing their overall judgment of his leadership.

4. **Halo Effect**
   - **Impact on Elections**: Voters may form an overall positive or negative impression of a candidate based on a single characteristic, which then colors their perception of all other aspects of the candidate.
   - **Examples**:
     - **Republican**: In 2016, Trump's image as a successful businessman created a halo effect, leading some voters to believe he would be equally successful in running the country, even if they had concerns about his political inexperience.
     - **Democrat**: In 2008, Barack Obama's charisma and eloquence created a halo effect, leading many voters to overlook his relative inexperience in favor of his promise of hope and change.
5. **Loss Aversion**
   - **Impact on Elections**: This bias makes voters more motivated by the fear of losing something than by the possibility of gaining something. In elections, this often manifests in fear-based messaging.
   - **Examples**:
     - **Republican**: In 2016, Trump's campaign effectively used loss aversion by emphasizing the dangers of illegal immigration and the loss of American jobs, which resonated with voters who feared economic decline and cultural change.
     - **Democrat**: In the 2020 election, Biden's campaign highlighted the potential losses associated with another four years of Trump's presidency, including threats to democracy, health care, and racial justice, which motivated many voters to support Biden.